

Professional Skills I: Presenting

Lecture Notes, Day 2

Main point of this session:

Meaningful gestures. Home bases.
Theatrical Sphere of Expression - the distance we need to fill physically and vocally to be clearly seen, heard and understood in a theatrical space.
Phrasing - the technique by which a speaker breaks up memorized text into understandable units (i.e. phrases)

Learning objectives for today:

- Start working with text
- Theatrical Sphere of Expression
- Phrasing, and acting the behavior of thinking

Activity (optional)

Clapping game to train presence

Meditation session (10-15 min)

Lie down
Stretch and get comfortable
Close your eyes, or keep them open if you prefer
Enter a state of embodiment without interruption from the language-based, intellectual mind
Feel your breath...
If a thought comes into your mind, acknowledge it and let it go...
Feel the ground beneath you supporting you...
If any of your muscles are tense, try to relax them: relax your face, ears, chin, neck, shoulder blades, spine, core, arms, legs, ankles, toes.
And if a thought enters your mind, acknowledge it and let it go.
Now, if you've had your eyes closed, open them
Let your eyes softly gaze around the room, noticing shapes, color, and texture.
Now find a spot on the wall or ceiling, and let your eyes rest there...

Now let your eyes move around the room, noticing shadows and objects in exquisite detail.

Review

Concentration. Why is it useful? Relaxation. Why is it useful? Breathing. Gazing. Grounding.

Note on making mistakes

Based on feedback we got last time, we want to explicitly say that mistakes in this class are welcome. In fact, mistakes are crucial. At ULTA, we have a mindset of making at least one mistake per day and learning from it. That applies especially to this course. It feels scary to stand up in front of peers and make a mistake, but that's the fastest way we all learn. This is a safe space where are all trying to improve.

Meaningful gesture (5 minutes)

Meaningful gesture - specific use of physicality / gesture to support the clarity of your storytelling (as opposed to random, vague or meaningless gesture born from a lack of concentration / relaxation)

Home bases (5 minutes)

Home bases - a form of meaningful gesture; "resting" postures for a character.

Exercise (15 minutes)

Students stand up (five at time, two groups total). We give home bases to try standing in, e.g., shy, confident, arrogant, angry.

[III] Theatrical Sphere of Expression

Theatrical Sphere of Expression - the distance we need to fill physically and vocally to be clearly seen, heard and understood in a theatrical space. In other words, be loud enough and expressive enough with your gestures.

— BREAK — (should happen around 45 minute mark)

[IV] Phrasing

Phrasing - the technique by which a speaker breaks up memorized text into understandable units (i.e. phrases); proper phrases are created by breathing in through the mouth at the punctuation, then speaking the phrase on the exhalation.

Note here: you don't close your mouth to take a breath.

Example (with & without phrasing)

Once upon a time, | in the heart of a forgotten kingdom, | there was a king who was loved by all. | He was a just king, | fair and wise, | and under his rule, | the kingdom prospered. | But even great kings | are not immune to sorrow.

His queen, | a woman of unparalleled intelligence and kindness, | fell ill. | The king was beside himself with grief, | but he refused to let go. | He summoned physicians from all corners of the world, | offered rewards, | and prayed to every god he knew. | But it was all in vain. |

One cold winter's night, | the queen slipped away quietly. | The king was devastated. | His grief was so great | that he shut himself away, | locked within the castle's highest tower. | There, | he would stay, | gazing out over his kingdom, | the kingdom that had once been filled with so much joy and prosperity, | now shrouded in sorrow. |

And yet, | in the midst of his despair, | the king learned a profound truth. | That life, | in all its beauty and cruelty, | continues to move forward, | even in the face of unimaginable loss. | He learned that love, | once given, | is never truly lost. | It lives on, | in the hearts of those we leave behind. |

This, | my dear friends, | is the tale of the sorrowful king. | A tale of love, | loss, | and the unyielding march of time. |

Exercise (phrasing)

Students take time (<10 minutes) to split the text into phrases, as mentioned earlier. Instructors are available for help/feedback.

Acting the behavior of thinking

Together with our phrases, we must act out the behavior accompanying the character's thought process.

Exercise (40 minutes)

Everybody gets up all at once, practices concentration and relaxation for 10 seconds, and then speaks. Students speak the first three sentences of their texts, exercising phrasing, and theatrical sphere of expression, while not forgetting concentration and relaxation.

Then, students all sit down. One student comes up at a time, in front of us, and speaks the first three sentences of their text, practicing concentration, relaxation, phrasing, and theatrical sphere of expression.